altogether a novel and frightening affair. Equally unnerving was the close media scrutiny. Each and every word spoken or written had to be absolutely non-controversial and not open to misunderstanding or misreporting. Gen Rawat had, on occasion, made off-the-cuff remarks or had been misquoted, leading to much debate, and I was acutely aware of this fact. Preparing for a press conference was like running the gauntlet.

My first interaction with the media was on 1 January 2020 itself, immediately after reviewing the Guard of Honour on the lawns of the South Block. In my opening, I greeted everyone by saying, '*Aap sab ko Sat Sri Akal*,' and continued by saying, '*Waheguru ki kripa se main Army Chief niyukt hua hoon*' (it is by the grace of God that I have been appointed as the Army Chief). This immediately caught the attention of the media and Army watchers, including veterans. It got a very positive response with many commenting that it highlighted the secular credentials of the Army.[1] I had said it spontaneously, what came naturally to me. It's the first thing I hear in the morning when my buddy wakes me up for PT, and I would have said it dozens of times each day, right from the day I got Commissioned in the Sikh Light Infantry. I don't remember much else of what I said. I was quite nervous, facing a battery of cameras and microphones and going 'live' nationally for the first time. It is not something that Officers are trained for; we are not media-savvy and that does tend to get us into hot water, as it did to me on a number of occasions.

Traditionally, the Chief and his spouse visit the Army Hospital (R&R) and the Base Hospital on New Year's Day and gift the patients some sweets or fruits. 1 January was my first day in office and full of ceremonial and other official events. However, we did not want to break with tradition and managed to squeeze in visits to both hospitals. One of the patients at the Base Hospital was none other than General JJ Singh, our

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